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The First Home Buyer's 90-Day Checklist — Australian Capital Territory

Everything you need to sort before you sign — including a genuinely historic change.

Correct as at July 2026. Grant amounts and thresholds are set by government and can change — always confirm current details with the ACT Revenue Office (revenue.act.gov.au) before relying on this for a purchase decision. This checklist is general information, not financial or legal advice.

Section 1 — A Nation-First Change You Need to Know About

- [ ] **Understand the ACT is now the first Australian jurisdiction to fully abolish stamp duty for all first home buyers.** From 1 July 2026, eligible first home buyer owner-occupiers pay **$0 conveyance duty (stamp duty)**, with **no price cap and no income test** — a genuinely major change from the ACT's previous Home Buyer Concession Scheme, which had capped eligibility at $1,020,000 and applied income thresholds.
- [ ] **Know this extends beyond just first home buyers.** The exemption also now covers owner-occupiers buying any **new unit-titled property** (including "missing middle" homes like townhouses and low-rise apartments), pensioners, eligible NDIS participants, and **anyone who hasn't owned property in the past 5 years**.
- [ ] **Understand there's no First Home Owner Grant in the ACT.** The ACT closed its cash FHOG in 2019 — your saving here comes entirely through the stamp duty abolition, not a grant payment.
- [ ] **Check the federal First Home Guarantee** (5% deposit, no LMI) — confirm current Canberra price caps with a participating lender; this operates independently of the ACT's own reforms.
- [ ] **Consider the First Home Super Saver Scheme (FHSSS)** if still building your deposit.
- [ ] **Get formal pre-approval, not just an estimate.**

Section 2 — While You're Searching

- [ ] **Set a firm maximum price** based on your pre-approval — since there's no price cap on the new exemption, this is about your genuine borrowing capacity, not a government-imposed threshold.
- [ ] **Budget for costs beyond the purchase price**: conveyancing fees, building and pest inspections, loan fees, and moving costs.
- [ ] **Understand ACT properties are leasehold, not freehold.** Land in the ACT is held under Crown lease (typically 99 years) rather than freehold title — this is a genuine structural difference from other states, though it rarely affects day-to-day ownership; your conveyancer can explain any specific implications for your purchase.

Section 3 — Know Your Legal Protections Before You Sign

- [ ] **Understand the cooling-off period.** You generally get **5 business days** after exchange to withdraw from a private treaty contract, governed by the Civil Law (Sale of Residential Property) Act 2003 (ACT).
- [ ] **Know the exit cost.** If you withdraw during the cooling-off period, you forfeit **0.25% of the purchase price**.
- [ ] **Know cooling-off doesn't apply at auction** — the contract becomes binding the moment the hammer falls, so all due diligence needs to be complete beforehand.
- [ ] **Know cooling-off can be waived** — via a solicitor's certificate and signed waiver — but think carefully before agreeing to this, as it removes a genuine protection.
- [ ] **Get a building and pest inspection done within your cooling-off window, or before auction day.**

Section 4 — Between Signing and Settlement

- [ ] **Confirm building insurance timing with your conveyancer.**
- [ ] **Finalise unconditional loan approval** well before settlement.
- [ ] **Book a pre-settlement inspection** in the days before settlement.
- [ ] **Confirm your stamp duty exemption paperwork is genuinely being applied under the new, uncapped settings** — given how recently this changed (1 July 2026), it's worth double-checking with your conveyancer that the exemption is being correctly claimed.

Section 5 — Common First-Home-Buyer Mistakes to Avoid

- [ ] **Don't assume there's a cash grant** — unlike most other states, ACT support is entirely through the duty exemption, not a payment on top.
- [ ] **Don't assume old $1,020,000-cap figures still apply** — the cap was removed entirely as part of the 1 July 2026 reform, so older articles or advice referencing that figure are now out of date.
- [ ] **Don't bid at auction without unconditional finance approval** — there's no cooling-off period to fall back on.

Quick Reference — ACT First Home Buyer Support (July 2026)

SUPPORT	AMOUNT / DETAIL	APPLIES TO
Stamp duty exemption	$0 duty, no price cap, no income test	First home buyer owner-occupiers, from 1 July 2026
Stamp duty exemption (new unit-titled homes)	$0 duty	Any owner-occupier buying new "missing middle" unit-titled property
First Home Owner Grant	**None** — closed in 2019	N/A

Cooling-off period	5 business days	Private treaty only, not auctions — 0.25% penalty to withdraw

Sources: ACT Revenue Office (revenue.act.gov.au), ACT Government 2026-27 Budget. Always verify current figures before making a purchase decision.